Clean is not a mood.

It's five decisions.

Hierarchy, contrast, space, color and alignment, shown on the same Faro dashboard before and after.

The problem

“Make it look cleaner” is feedback, not a direction

When people call an interface clean, they are reacting to something concrete. Once you can name it, polish stops being luck and becomes something you produce on purpose.

Hierarchy: one thing clearly leads

A — no hierarchy

Checkout Redesign Q3

Share

Sessions this week
1,847
+6% vs last week

Checkout completion
67%
down from 72%

Drop-off at step 4
41%
Shipping cost step

Surfaced insight
"In 3 interviews last month, users mentioned abandoning checkout when shipping costs appeared late."
User Interview Round 12, Aug 2026

Recent research
Checkout Usability Test — Round 8
Shipping Cost Interview Series
Q3 Pricing Perception Survey

From your team
"Users trust itemized cost breakdowns more than single totals" — Mia
"Mobile users expect to edit quantities inline" — Jonas

B — clear hierarchy

Checkout Redesign Q3

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A: no hierarchy. B: size, weight, color, space and position decide what you see first.

Contrast

Same on purpose, or different on purpose

Avoid the almost-same. Two things that are nearly aligned, nearly the same size or nearly the same color read as sloppy, even to people who can’t say why.

Space: remove before you add

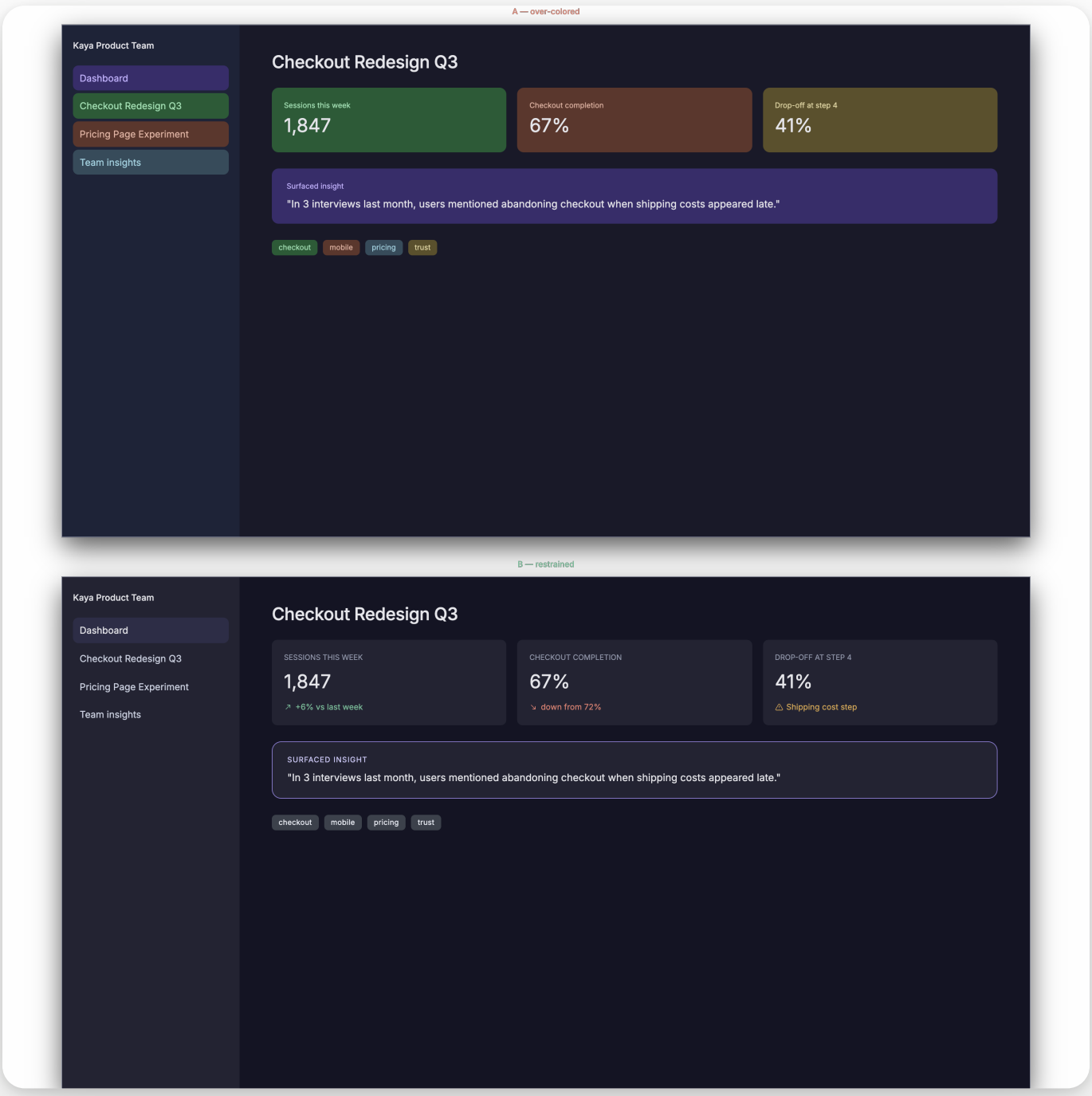
1 Pick a spacing scale, for example 4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32, 48, 64

2 Keep space inside a group smaller than space between groups

3 Step up in clear jumps, never 16 next to 20

4 Start generous, then tighten. Squint to check the groups

Color: meaning, not decoration



A: color on everything, so nothing stands out. B: neutrals carry the screen, color marks what matters.

Alignment: fewer edges, calmer screen



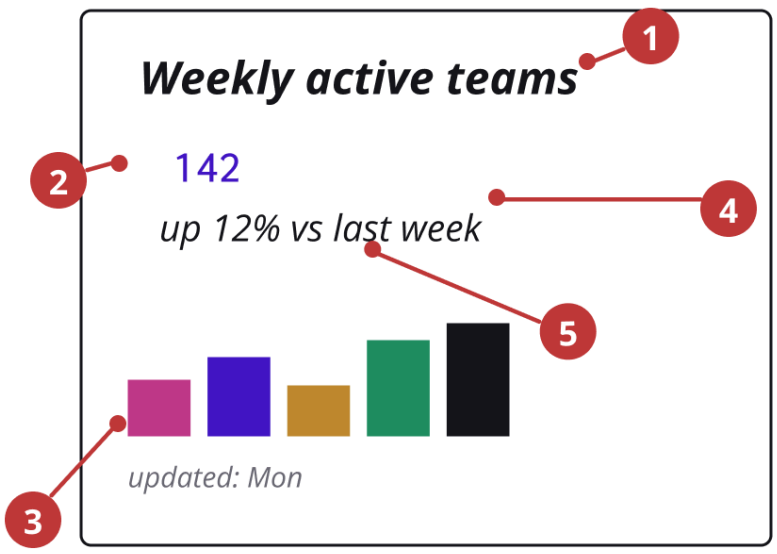
A: everything sits on one grid. B: the same elements, nudged slightly off it.

All five, on one small card

FIG 21.6 - CH21

One analytics card, fixed five ways

✕ Before



1 **Hierarchy**
label beats the number

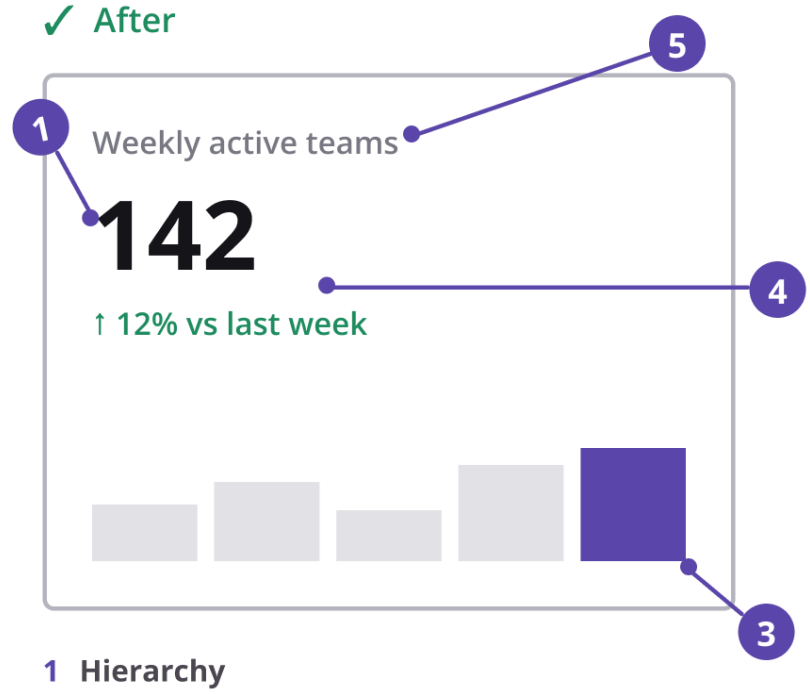
2 **Alignment**
three different edges

3 **Color**
five random colors

4 **Spacing**
every gap different

5 **Type**
four styles at once

✓ After



1 **Hierarchy**
the number leads

2 **Alignment**
one left edge

3 **Color**
accent marks this week

4 **Spacing**
one steady rhythm

5 **Type**
one family, three sizes

Same data, same size. None of the five fixes adds anything. Each one takes something away.

Good visual design *is rarely noticed*.

FROM THE BOOK

Product Design *Unlocked.*

The whole picture of UX and product design.

This carousel is adapted from Chapter 21: Visual Design Fundamentals.

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